

Egg laying

Nourished by the male's body, the pregnant female can now lay her eggs. She lays 100–200 eggs in a mass of froth produced by glands in her abdomen (the rear part of the body).

Hard case

The froth hardens to form a protective egg case called an ootheca, which is often wrapped around the stem of a plant.

Breaking out

Tiny nymphs emerge from the ootheca. They hang down on threads, before splitting their saclike covering and setting off on their own.

See also

Find out about earthworms (74–75) and spiders (76–77), who also produce babies from egg cases or cocoons.

Becoming an adult

The nymphs molt (shed their skin) up to eight times before they become adults. European mantises can live for about a year in the wild, if they escape predators.

Ultimate sacrifice The mother black lace-weaver spider sacrifices herself to her babies. The young spiders gain vital nutrients by eating their mother's body, which helps keep them healthy.



Black widow The female black widow spider sometimes eats the much smaller male after mating. Males try to choose a mate who has already eaten, so that she is less likely to feel hungry and eat them!

